

# Thanks But No Thanks

The ruling alliance's attempt to adopt minorityism as a credo is being met with stiff resistance from voters across the country



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It is often said of the leadership of the Muslim minorities they would rather that their people stay backward so that they remain a dependable vote bank in perpetuity. For over 50 years, the Congress too has done just that. But ever since the party lost the trust of the minority community—and with it power in many crucial states—the Congress has been at pains to find a way back into Muslim hearts. Last year, the Congress Government in Andhra Pradesh attempted to implement a separate quota for Muslims only to be rebuffed by the Supreme Court. Yet, the UPA Government hasn't given up and more than a handful of GOMs are looking at ways to bring in quotas in one way or the other.

The Supreme Court's reaction to the attempts of the Government in Hyderabad is reflected in the Mood of the Nation Poll, which shows that the ruling alliance's bids to adopt minorityism as a credo will be met with stiff resistance from voters across the

country—51 per cent think there should be no quotas based on religion. To another query relating to the conditions of Muslims in India, the fact that 54 per cent of voters in Andhra Pradesh—the state where the local government tried to introduce reservation for Muslims as part of its plans to consolidate its base for future electoral battles—thought Muslims had as good educational and job opportunities as everyone else, is perhaps a pointer that UPA would invite a serious backlash if it went ahead with its plans to try and fill its electoral kitty in the garb of social upliftment. The poll gives some hint that the minorities have started seeing through the Congress's strategy of simply taking them as a votebank. Asked if they would like to enjoy the benefits of reservation, 47 per cent of Muslim voters across the country said they were against reservations on the basis of religion, while only 37 per cent were in favour of it. Thanks, but no thanks.

by Ashok K. Damodaran

**Should there be reservations based on religion?**

**34**

(31)

**YES**

**51**

(47)

**NO**

All figures in per cent  
Rest: Don't know/Can't say  
Figures in brackets indicate percentage in February 2007

**What do you think about the UPA's current reservation policy for OBCs?**

Approve

**36**

2007  
33

No opinion

**24**

21

Disapprove

**17**

17

All figures in per cent Rest: Don't know/Can't say

**What do you think about the condition of Muslims in India?**

Have same opportunities as others

**31**

2007  
27

Responsible for their condition

**25**

28

Lack in education

**14**

13

Neglected by government

**11**

8

Lack opportunities

**6**

6

All figures in per cent Rest: Don't know/Can't say

**Would you allow your child to marry outside your caste or religion?**

**54**

**No to both**

Allow only inter-caste

**25**

Yes to both

**5**

All figures in per cent Rest: Don't know/Can't say